

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

Index No.:

Purchased _____

-----X
OTIS REESE,

Plaintiff,

-against-

Plaintiff designates
BRONX County as the place of trial

The basis of the venue is where the
tort arose and where plaintiff resides

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, MICHAEL CAUTILLO
P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND,
SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562, MICHAEL
BLETCH SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740, AND
OTHER NEW YORK CITY POLICE OFFICERS ON
ARREST #B16615891 WHOSE NAMES ARE NOT
KNOWN AT THIS TIME N/H/A JOHN/JANE DOE
I-IV, AS IT PERTAINS TO THE INCIDENT THAT
Arose ON MARCH 16, 2016 AND NO OTHER,

SUMMONS

Plaintiff resides at

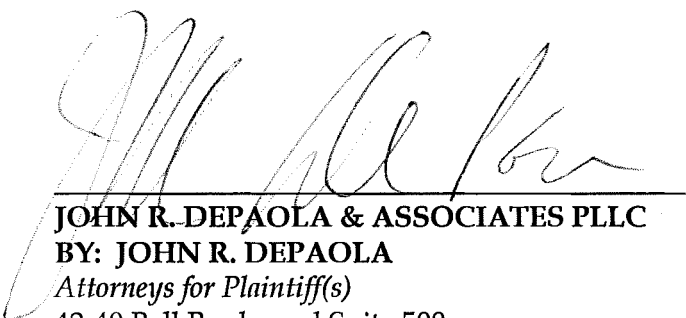
OTIS REESE
1008 Garrison Avenue
Bronx, New York 10474

Defendants.
-----X

TO THE ABOVE NAMED DEFENDANT:

YOU ARE HEREBY SUMMONED, to answer the complaint in this action and to serve a copy of your answer, or if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance, on the Plaintiff's Attorney(s) within 20 days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service (or within 30 days after the service is complete if this summons is not personally delivered to you within the State of New York); and in case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

Dated: Bayside, New York
October 24, 2018



JOHN R. DEPAOLA & ASSOCIATES PLLC

BY: JOHN R. DEPAOLA

Attorneys for Plaintiff(s)

42-40 Bell Boulevard Suite 500
Bayside, New York 11361
(718) 281-0400 / (718) 281-4000

Defendants' Addresses:

**CORPORATION COUNSEL OF THE
CITY OF NEW YORK**

100 Church Street
New York, New York 10007

**MICHAEL CAUTILLO P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND
SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562**

5 Central Road
New York, New York 10035

**MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7
TAX ID #929740**

737 Melrose Avenue
Bronx, New York 10455

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

Index No.:

Purchased _____

-----X
OTIS REESE,

Plaintiff,

-against-

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, MICHAEL CAUTILLO
P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND,
SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562, MICHAEL
BLETCH SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740, AND
OTHER NEW YORK CITY POLICE OFFICERS ON
ARREST #B16615891 WHOSE NAMES ARE NOT
KNOWN AT THIS TIME N/H/A JOHN/JANE DOE I-
IV, AS IT PERTAINS TO THE INCIDENT THAT
Arose ON MARCH 16, 2016 AND NO OTHER,

Defendants.

-----X

OTIS REESE, by his attorneys, JOHN R. DEPAOLA & ASSOCIATES PLLC,
respectfully alleges as follows:

AS AND FOR A FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

1. At all times mentioned, Plaintiff OTIS REESE was a resident of Bronx County, City and State of New York.
2. At all times mentioned, Defendant CITY OF NEW YORK, was and is a municipal corporation duly organized and existing by virtue of the laws of the State of New York.
3. On or about the 31st day of August, 2018 and within ninety (90) days after some of the claims herein arose, the Plaintiff served a Notice of Claim in writing sworn to on their behalf upon the Defendant CITY OF NEW YORK, by delivering a copy thereof in duplicate to the officer designated to receive such process personally, which Notice of Claim advised the Defendant CITY

OF NEW YORK, of the nature, place, time and manner in which the claim arose, the items of damage and injuries sustained so far as was then determinable.

4. At least thirty (30) days have elapsed since the service of the claim prior to the commencement of this action and adjustment of payment thereof has been neglected or refused, and this action has been commenced within one year and ninety (90) days after the happening of the event upon which the claims are based.
5. The Plaintiff has complied with the request of the municipal Defendant's for an oral examination pursuant to Section 50-H of the General Municipal Law and/or the Public Authorities Law and/or no such request was made within the applicable period.
6. Upon information and belief, at all times mentioned, Defendants **MICHAEL CAUTILLO P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND, SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562, MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740, AND OTHER NEW YORK CITY POLICE OFFICERS ON ARREST #B16615891 WHOSE NAMES ARE NOT KNOWN AT THIS TIME N/H/A JOHN/JANE DOE I-IV**, were and are police officers of the Defendant City of New York, and at all times herein were acting in such capacity as the agents, servants and employees of the Defendant, **THE CITY OF NEW YORK**.
7. On or about March 16, 2016, at approximately 6:50 P.M., in the vicinity of the inside of 3103 3rd Avenue, County of Bronx, State of New York the Defendants jointly and severally in their capacity as police officers, wrongfully touched, grabbed, handcuffed and seized the Plaintiff **OTIS**

REESE, in an excessive manner about his person, causing him physical pain and mental suffering. At no time did the Defendants have legal cause to grab, handcuff seize or touch the Plaintiff, nor did the Plaintiff consent to this illegal touching nor was it privileged by law.

AS AND FOR A SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

8. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates and re-alleges all of the allegations contained in Paragraphs "1" through "7" with full force and effect as though set forth at length herein.
9. On or about March 16, 2016, at approximately 6:50 P.M., in the vicinity of the inside of 3103 3rd Avenue, County of Bronx, State of New York, the Defendants jointly and severally did place Plaintiff OTIS REESE in imminent fear of physical contact by approaching the Plaintiff with their loaded firearms, outstretched limbs and other objects which they used to physically seize, strike and restrain the Plaintiff. All of the above actions placed the Plaintiff in imminent fear of physical contact. At no time did the Plaintiff consent to the unlawful actions of the Defendants.

AS AND FOR A THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

10. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates and re-alleges all of the allegations contained in Paragraphs "1" through "9" with full force and effect as though set forth at length herein.
11. On or about March 16, 2016, at approximately 6:50 P.M., in the vicinity of the inside of 3103 3rd Avenue, County of Bronx, State of New York the Defendants, jointly and severally without any warrant, order or other legal process and without any legal right, wrongfully and unlawfully arrested the

Plaintiff, restrained him and his liberty and then took him into custody to a police station in the County of Bronx and there charged him with the crimes on Docket No. 2016BX011960. The Plaintiff was thereafter held in custody over the course of approximately five to six (5-6) days until he was released. The Defendants intentionally confined the Plaintiff without his consent and the confinement was not otherwise privileged by law and, at all times, the Plaintiff was conscious of his confinement.

AS AND FOR A FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

12. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates and re-alleges all of the allegations contained in Paragraphs "1" through "11" with full force and effect as though set forth at length herein.
13. On or about March 16, 2016, at approximately 6:50 P.M., in the vicinity of the inside of 3103 3rd Avenue, County of Bronx, State of New York the Defendants, jointly and severally without any valid warrant, order or other legal process and without any legal right, wrongfully and unlawfully imprisoned the Plaintiff, restrained him and his liberty and then took him into custody and causing him to be incarcerated as a detainee in the City of New York's Correctional Facility. The Plaintiff was thereafter held in custody over the course of five to six (5-6) days before he was released when Plaintiff posted bail. The Defendants intentionally confined the Plaintiff without his consent and the confinement was not otherwise privileged by law and, at all times, the Plaintiff was conscious of his confinement.

AS AND FOR A FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

14. Plaintiff incorporates, repeats, and re-alleges all of the allegations contained in Paragraphs "1" through "13" with full force and effect as though set forth at length herein.
15. Upon information and belief, on or about March 16, 2016 and from that time until the dismissal of charges on or about August 14, 2018, which was a favorable termination for the accused, by the Honorable P. Perry presiding at Bronx County Criminal Court, Part AP3, Defendants **THE CITY OF NEW YORK, MICHAEL CAUTILLO P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND, SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562, MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740, AND OTHER NEW YORK CITY POLICE OFFICERS ON ARREST #B16615891 WHOSE NAMES ARE NOT KNOWN AT THIS TIME N/H/A JOHN/JANE DOE I-IV**, deliberately and maliciously prosecuted Plaintiff, **OTIS REESE**, an innocent man without any probable cause whatsoever, by filing or causing a criminal court complaint to be filed in the Criminal Court of the City of New York, Bronx County, for the purpose of falsely accusing the plaintiff of violations of the criminal laws of the State of New York. The Defendants had no right to stop, search and seize the Plaintiff as he had committed no crimes or violations of the law in the presence of the police defendants. Notwithstanding the above, the defendants and their police officers in particular gave false statements to the Court and Bronx District Attorneys so that a prosecution would be initiated against the Plaintiff for reasons that were personal to the individually named officers as the Plaintiff had filed a complaint against one of the Defendants in

the past, and had not observed the Plaintiff commit any violations of the law. Their predicate for having probable cause to arrest the Plaintiff was based on purported stated facts that were known to be false and a video unequivocally demonstrated the falsehood of Defendant Cautillo's statements. He testified at a hearing under oath that he saw that the Plaintiff had a beer bottle in a paper bag which had no cap on it, the Court while viewing the video tape from the Deli came to a different conclusion stating the tape revealed Police Officer Cautillo tried to open the beer bottle that was in the paper bag and could not as Corona beer bottles are not twist off bottles. Further, Officer Cautillo stated at the hearing that his partner Sgt. Bletcha had observed the defendant drinking out of the alleged open container. See page 9 of Judge Pitt's written decision at footnote 4. The above is believed by the Court's interpretation of the video footage that the cap was on the bottle when Plaintiff entered the Deli. Officer Cautillo was noted for changing his testimony numerous times and flip flopping as to his testimony.

16. The Defendants, jointly and severally, their agents, servants or employees failed to take reasonable steps to stop the prosecution of the Plaintiff and instead maliciously and deliberately provided false and/or incomplete information as stated above to the District Attorney's office to induce prosecution of the Plaintiff and due to the absence of probable cause malice can be inferred.
17. The commencement of these criminal proceedings under Docket No. 2016BX011960 was malicious and began in malice and without probable cause, so that the proceedings could succeed by the Defendants.

18. As a result of the malicious prosecution, Plaintiff was deprived of his liberty and suffered the humiliation, mental anguish, indignity and frustration of an unjust criminal prosecution. The Plaintiff made multiple court appearances to defend his liberty against these unjust charges.

AS AND FOR A SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION

(This Cause of action only applies against the Individually named Police Officers not the City of New York or officers sued in their official capacity)

19. Plaintiff incorporates, repeats, and re-alleges all of the allegations contained in Paragraphs "1" through "18" with full force and effect as though set forth at length herein.
20. Defendants **MICHAEL CAUTILLO P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND, SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562, MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740, AND OTHER NEW YORK CITY POLICE OFFICERS ON ARREST #B16615891 WHOSE NAMES ARE NOT KNOWN AT THIS TIME N/H/A JOHN/JANE DOE I-IV**, were at all times relevant, duly appointed and acting officers of the City of New York Police Department.
21. At all times mentioned herein, said police officers were acting under color of law, to wit: the statutes, ordinances, regulations, policies and customs and usage of the State of New York and/or City of New York.
22. Plaintiff **OTIS REESE** is and at all times relevant herein, a citizen of the United States and a resident of Bronx County in the State of New York and

brings this cause of action pursuant to 42 United States Code, Section 1983 and 42 United States Code, Section 1988.

23. The Defendant **CITY OF NEW YORK** is a municipality duly incorporated under the laws of the State of New York.
24. On or about March 16, 2016, the Defendants, armed police, while effectuating the seizure of the Plaintiff **OTIS REESE**, did search, seize, assault and commit a battery and grab the person of the Plaintiff without a court authorized arrest or search warrant. They did physically seize the person of the Plaintiff during the arrest process in an unlawful and excessive manner. The Plaintiff was falsely arrested, unlawfully imprisoned, assaulted, and had multiple batteries committed against him, without the Defendants possessing probable cause to do so. **MICHAEL CAUTILLO P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND, SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562** was the arresting officer, **MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740** was his supervisor. The Plaintiff was illegally searched and seized. **MICHAEL CAUTILLO P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND, SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562, MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740** along with **JOHN/JANE DOE I-IV** provided false information in the criminal court complaint he drafted leading to plaintiff being maliciously prosecuted in this matter. **MICHAEL CAUTILLO P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND, SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562** swore in an affidavit that he determined that Plaintiff was in criminal possession of contraband even though he had no facts that he observed that would allow the Plaintiff to be stopped, let alone searched, seized, arrested

and later at the police station strip-searched with cavity inspection at the direction of the individually named defendants. These individually named officers told the Bronx District Attorney's Office that they saw Mr. Reese unscrew the top of a beer bottle which was in a paper bag and **MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740** saw him drink from it, as per Officer Cautillo telling the Court these numerous falsehoods while under oath; he stated he saw Mr. Reese unscrew the cap and that **MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740** told him he saw Plaintiff drink from it, which was false, since the store video demonstrated that Officer Cautillo attempted to unscrew the beer bottle cap but he could not since it was still sealed contradicting his statement., **MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740** told Cautillo as per Cautillo that the Plaintiff had drunk from it in public. The Court viewed the video and found at a suppression hearing that Police Officer Cautillo was being disingenuous and falsified his testimony as the video contradicted his predicate for probable cause to seize, search and arrest the Plaintiff. The Defendant expressly testified he saw the Plaintiff with a clear bottle within a brown paper bag, he stated based on his training and prior experiences he recognized it as a beer bottle, that he said it was opened because he did not see the cap on the top and liquid was missing from the bottle. He said the Plaintiff walked into the New York's Finest Deli and Officer Cautillo parked his unmarked police car and followed the Plaintiff into the New York's Finest Deli while never losing sight of the Plaintiff which later turned out on cross-examination to be a false statement, **MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740** also

made false statements. Officer, Cautillo stated the bottle of beer was found open with the seal broken and the cap off with liquid missing from the bottle. The Court's view of the video was inconsistent with Officer Cautillo's testimony, since the Court saw that when Officer Cautillo "twists the cap" it does not move, let alone come off the bottle. The court in the criminal proceeding when considering officer Cautillo's testimony and the video surveillance footage found numerous inconsistencies which were related to material testimony and collateral facts, the court could not credit officer Cautillo's testimony and found evidence introduced at the suppression hearing did not support the conclusion that probable cause existed for Officer Cautillo to issue a summons or arrest the Plaintiff for a violation of the open container law administration code of the City of New York Section 10-125[b]. The named officers and/or otherwise, along with those named as **JOHN/JANE DOE I-IV** assisted in the investigation that led to the arrest of the Plaintiff. The Plaintiff is not certain of the officer who actually placed him in handcuffs. The handcuffs were placed on Plaintiff's wrists so tight that Plaintiff's wrists turned red.

25. The above action of the Defendants resulted in the Plaintiff being deprived of the following rights protected under the United States Constitution:
- a. Freedom from assault to his person;
 - b. Freedom from battery to his person;
 - c. Freedom from illegal search and seizure;
 - d. Freedom from false arrest;
 - e. Freedom from malicious prosecution;

- f. Freedom from the use of excessive force during the arrest process;
 - g. Freedom from unlawful imprisonment for multiple months;
 - h. Freedom from loss of his liberty for multiple months.
 - i. Freedom from being illegally strip-searched with a cavity inspections on multiple occasions by both individually named defendants.
26. The Defendants subjected the Plaintiff to such deprivations, either in a malicious or reckless disregard of the Plaintiff's rights or with deliberate indifference to those rights protected under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.
27. The direct and proximate result of the Defendants' acts are that the Plaintiff has suffered severe and permanent injuries of a psychological nature. He was forced to endure pain and suffering, all to his detriment and lost his liberty for approximately six to six and a half (6-6½) months.

AS AND FOR A SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

28. Plaintiff incorporates, repeats and re-alleges all of the allegations contained in Paragraphs "1" through "27" with full force and effect as though set forth at length herein.
29. Defendant **CITY OF NEW YORK** has grossly failed to train and adequately supervise its police officers in the fundamental law of arrest, search and seizure especially when its police officers are not in possession of a court authorized arrest warrant and where an individual, especially as here, has not committed a crime and has not resisted arrest, that its police officers should only use reasonable force to effectuate an arrest and the arrest should be based on probable cause.

30. THE CITY OF NEW YORK was negligent by failing to implement a policy with its Police Department and instruct police officers who, absent the consent of the Plaintiff (or similarly situated individuals) or without the possession of a court authorized arrest a search warrant, said police officers of the City of New York are not to arrest individuals such as the Plaintiff here where probable cause is lacking and the use of force should only be reasonable when an individual resists arrest and should not be used where a criminal defendant is not resisting arrest.
31. THE CITY OF NEW YORK is negligent due to its failure to implement a policy with its Police Department or actively enforce the law, if any of the following are lacking:
1. Probable cause must be present before an individual such as the Plaintiff herein can be arrested.
 2. Excessive force cannot be used against an individual who does not physically resist arrest.
 3. An individual cannot be strip-searched with a cavity inspection unless the Defendants possess probable cause to believe the Plaintiff has secreted contraband in or on his person.
31. The foregoing acts, omissions and systemic failures are customs and policies of the CITY OF NEW YORK which caused the police officers to falsely arrest, maliciously prosecute, seize illegally and search the Plaintiff commit an assault/battery to his person and denied him prompt medical attention under the belief that they would suffer no disciplinary actions for their failure to take proper or prudent steps in this case.

AS AND FOR AN EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

32. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges all of the allegations contained in paragraphs "1" through "31" as it set forth at length herein.
33. Defendant **CITY OF NEW YORK** was negligent in that prior to and at the time of the acts complained of herein, due to the prior history of the Police Officer Defendants, knew or should have known of the bad disposition of said Defendants or had knowledge of facts that would put a reasonably prudent employer on inquiry concerning their bad disposition and the fact that these officers were not suitable to be hired and employed by the **CITY OF NEW YORK** and that due to their lack of training, these officers should have had adequate supervision so that they would not arrest innocent individuals nor use excessive force during the arrest process.

WHEREFORE, Plaintiff demands judgment against the Defendants, together with the costs and disbursements of this action in the amount of damages greater than the jurisdictional limit of any lower court where otherwise have jurisdiction, together with attorneys' fees and costs for bringing this case and punitive damages.

Dated: Bayside, New York
October 24, 2018

Yours, etc.

JOHN R. DEPAOLA & ASSOCIATES PLLC

BY: **JOHN R. DEPAOLA**
Attorneys for Plaintiff(s)
42-40 Bell Boulevard Suite 500
Bayside, New York 11361
(718) 281-0400 / (718) 281-4000

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

Index No.:

Purchased _____

-----X
OTIS REESE,

Plaintiff,

-against-

VERIFICATION

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, MICHAEL CAUTILLO
P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE COMMAND,
SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562, MICHAEL
BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID #929740, AND
OTHER NEW YORK CITY POLICE OFFICERS ON
ARREST #B16615891 WHOSE NAMES ARE NOT
KNOWN AT THIS TIME N/H/A JOHN/JANE DOE
I-IV, AS IT PERTAINS TO THE INCIDENT THAT
AROSE ON MARCH 16, 2016 AND NO OTHER,

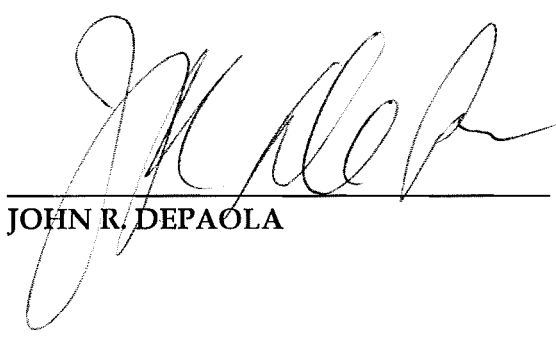
Defendants.

-----X

I, JOHN R. DEPAOLA, an attorney admitted to practice in the courts of New York State, state that I am a member of the firm of **JOHN R. DEPAOLA & ASSOCIATES PLLC**, the attorneys of record for Plaintiffs in the within action; I have read the foregoing and know the contents thereof; the same is true to my own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged on information and belief, and as to those matters I believe it to be true. The reason this verification is made by me and not by Plaintiff is because Plaintiff resides outside the county where deponent maintains his office.

I affirm that the foregoing statements are true, under the penalties of perjury.

Dated: Bayside, New York
October 24, 2018



JOHN R. DEPAOLA

Index No.:

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

OTIS REESE,

Plaintiff,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, MICHAEL CAUTILLO P.O. OF CRITICAL RESPONSE
COMMAND, SHIELD #245, TAX ID #952562, MICHAEL BLETCHA SGT. OF PSA 7, TAX ID
#929740, AND OTHER NEW YORK CITY POLICE OFFICERS ON ARREST #B16615891
WHOSE NAMES ARE NOT KNOWN AT THIS TIME N/H/A JOHN/JANE DOE I-IV, AS IT
PERTAINS TO THE INCIDENT THAT AROSE ON MARCH 16, 2016 AND NO OTHER,

Defendants.

SUMMONS AND VERIFIED COMPLAINT

JOHN R. DEPAOLA & ASSOCIATES PLLC
BY: JOHN R. DEPAOLA
Attorney for Plaintiff(s)
42-40 Bell Boulevard
Bayside, NY 11361
Tel. (718) 281-4000

To: CORPORATION COUNSEL OF NEW YORK CITY

Attorney(s) for Defendants

Service of a copy of the within is hereby admitted.

Dated _____

Attorney(s) for